transmission may have occurred, the paper argued, via Malayan pangolins in Southeast Asia – which, the paper helpfully pointed out, neighbours India and Bangladesh. While this was not altogether implausible, weeks later the paper was withdrawn.[87]

What the Indian media failed to tell its readers was that Indian scientists too had made misleading claims about the origins of the coronavirus as early as February 2020, just weeks after the outbreak of the disease. A pre-print of an article by Indian researchers suggested that Covid-19 'may have been deliberately engineered using the HIV [virus]'. This 'fed conspiracy theories that the new virus might be a bioweapon' – perhaps it fed Manish Tewari's imagination. It quickly elicited criticism from Chinese researchers based in the US and China. Days after it appeared, the Indian scientists pulled the paper from the website where it had been originally uploaded.[88]



We are brought up to think that mass education, the growth of international travel, the exchange of goods and services across borders, and modern communications bring societies closer together: they learn more about other peoples, develop an appreciation of foreign cultures, discover common interests, and, in the end, find ways to live harmoniously (or at least peacefully) side by side. Our review of recent Indian and Chinese perceptions suggests that the people of the two countries see the other society in increasingly negative ways. Are there other 'ways of seeing' (to use the critic and novelist John Berger's famous phrase) which take a kinder view?[89]

Worldviews

India and China engage each other and the rest of the world via 'worldviews' – lenses through which they see themselves, the future of world history, and, by extrapolation, each other. Societies have all kinds of lenses by which they organize reality, and the three described here are not